

What the evidence can carry

SHORT REFLECTION | Beyond Sedona

The evidence revised the premise

The project began with the idea that a sudden visitor influx in one city could benefit nearby communities. The selected Arizona park records did not establish such a surge: all six parks recorded fewer visits in 2025 than in 2024. This is not proof that Sedona tourism as a whole declined, because the sample covers specific attractions. It did justify reframing the study around seasonal side-trip promotion rather than treating an unverified surge as fact.

What the data supports

The strongest evidence concerns seasonal timing. Slide Rock received 34.9% of annual visits in June-August 2025, while Jerome State Historic Park received 16.5%. Dead Horse Ranch's September count was about 51% of its own peak month. These differences support screening a September Cottonwood itinerary, a modest summer history option in Jerome, and an off-peak Fort Verde test. They identify hypotheses worth investigating; they do not establish an optimal destination ranking.

What the data cannot prove

Lower attendance is not evidence of spare capacity. Heat, opening days, staffing, parking, events and ecological limits can all affect counts. Two years cannot establish a long-term trend or explain the causes of change. Park visits also include repeat visits and local users; they are not a census of unique tourists or total town visitation.

Why spending and resident views need boundaries

The spending estimates concern non-local visitor activity within 50 miles of each park. These areas overlap and may include Sedona itself, so the estimates cannot be added into a regional windfall or used to predict new campaign revenue. Sedona's weighted resident survey provides a reason to take local impacts seriously, but it does not speak for Cottonwood, Jerome or Camp Verde. Survey nonresponse and missing receiving-community feedback remain limitations.

The practical conclusion

The website is useful as a transparent screening tool for small pilots. The next step is to ask local partners about capacity and priorities, confirm access and conditions, and test visitor interest. Evaluation should track local business participation, resident feedback and crowding, while asking whether side trips replace time in Sedona or extend a trip. The central lesson is that a credible recommendation makes its assumptions visible and states what evidence would be needed before expanding it.

Sources and definitions supporting this reflection